

9.1 The Value Of Forums

Forums are one of the most popular forms of online communication and idea sharing. A forum is, very simply put, a sort of group discussion carried on online, the participants of which form a community with common interests. A forum has no rigorous organisation, and is the sum total of its members' contributions. The beauty of a forum is that it can be specific or general; forums have topic heads, where varying subjects can be discussed, but under the proper category. Without actually having to leave the safe realm of your desktop, you could exchange shooting tips with a photographer from the US and another from Germany, for example. Today there are thousands of forums up and running, with members running into the millions!

Nobody today can afford to miss out on the forum fever that's gripping a sizable chunk of the online community. Some manufacturers also have separate forums on their Web sites; hardcore hardware testing authorities such as Tomshardware (www.tomshardware.com), Hard OCP (www.hardocp.com), and Guru 3D (www.guru3d.com) all have dedicated forums where visitors can become members and post queries or display their over-clocked rigs. Almost every niche Web site will have a dedicated forum, and you can find a forum to cater to almost any like, from cooking to biking to home decorating. People become members of forums because they have interests in common, and can exchange ideas or views about a specific topic—a so called “expert opinion,” if helpful, will garner respect for the poster of the tip.

There are also quite a few forums around that organise meets for members of say, a particular city, and members are also free to exchange personal information, although privately—that is, usually not on the forum posts themselves.

People, therefore, can not only make friends online, but also learn and further the knowledge in their fields of interest. If a person is interested in biking and computer hardware, there will, of